and supply business open to anyone—by simply doing away with the requirement of a licence to set up such a business. The government has proposed to do away with distribution licencing in the new Electricity Bill. However, a collateral casualty of three farm laws is postponement of this Bill till its provisions affecting agricultural power supply are discussed with farmers' representatives. The government should use this opportunity to bring a comprehensive reform bill addressing all the needed policy measures outlined above.

Third, piped natural gas supply, in whatever possible variants, is not only efficient and clean but quite competitive, even considering international prices. India is deficient in not just oil but also gas. Oil is our largest item of imports. Gas imports are relatively small at present. However, if the country were to aggressively go in for a national piped natural gas system for residential cooking and transportation fuel, this import bill would go up. That should, however, be fine. It will partly substitute import of oil. And as oil prices are on a decline given the global demand-and-supply situation, gas imports are likely to remain relatively benign in times to come. India should, therefore, opt for a piped natural gas supply system. The government has awarded concessions for city gas supply. Many of these concessions have gone to the private sector but there is still a large number of concessions bagged by PSUs or companies like Indraprastha Gas and Mahanagar Gas, which are private sector only in name. In the gas transmission and supply sector, the policy reform agenda needs to be built around separating the gas grid and gas supply business of GAIL on the lines of the separation of the power generation and transmission business of NTPC, strengthening the Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Authority for regulating the gas grid business, aggressive concessioning of city gas and other natural gas supply networks and ultimate privatization of gas supply businesses housed in GAIL and joint-sector companies like Indraprastha Gas.